My Primary School is at the Museum

An Introduction to MPSM – Founded in the UK; expanding into EU



MPSM: Story Telling History in the Museum.

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"My Primary School is at the Museum" (MPSM) is a project for children to spend extended, immersive time at a museum, undertaking their full cross-curriculum education. Imagining it would be for 5–11 year olds at inception, MPSM has benefitted many 0–11 year olds over the last 8 years.

Not only do the children benefit from MPSM, but also the families and educators.[1] "Who am I?" and "where do I come from?" are exciting questions in this context. MPSM is object-based, in settings relevant to the children's culture and heritage. It brings wider inclusivity and accessibility to children of all backgrounds and capabilities.

MPSM is particularly good for those children found "at the edges" of traditional classrooms; those with neurodiverse or special needs. MPSM gives children the support and freedom to respond and grow in out of school settings.

MPSM projects thrive, generating happiness, health and wellbeing for children, educators and museums. Educators experience a valued "change of scene"; CPD that re-energizes and motivates them.

MPSM exists in different school systems: England, Wales, Scotland, the Republic of Ireland, Germany and Norway, all using different curricula. Here are 3 project snapshots:

- In Swansea, Wales at the National Waterfront Museum, 60 4–5 year olds spent 5 weeks, immersed in the museum environment of harbour, social and industrial heritage of the Welsh valleys. There was also the beach and a sea trip; the poetry of Dylan Thomas and history from where the UK's National Health Service was born. Children happily made the museum their home, and the teachers didn't want to leave!
- In Dublin, Ireland, two classes of 8–10 year olds with severe dyslexia spent two weeks at the National Gallery of Ireland across all curriculum subjects.[2] Despite their dyslexia, all confidently, proudly and creatively curated a final exhibition visited by over 2000 people.
- In Bergen, Norway, two kindergartens, each with 16 children aged 4–5, participated in a 2 week residency at the University Museum, Department of Cultural History. With daycare staff, the children moved into the museum, bringing suitcases full of personal treasures to foster ownership and connection to the space. They explored exhibitions and artefacts with their whole bodies and minds. Using storytelling, dramatic play, and drawing, the children's impressions created meaning from what they encountered. As active participants, storytellers, and explorers, the children shaped the museum space, deepening their sense of identity, belonging, and Bergen citizenship, making the museum an exciting and vibrant place to be.



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[1] DeWitt, J., King, H., Wright, D. and Measures, K. (2018): The potential of extended cultural residencies for young children. Museum Management and Curatorship, 33:2, 158–177.

[2] Austin, S. (2024): Geographical adventures in residence at the National Gallery of Ireland. Primary Geography, 114: Summer 2024, 22–23.